MONARQUE: CARDS OF THE FALLEN

Redesign Plan — Revision 3

Original-IP grim dark fantasy • mystical beings • psychological and occult horror

A redesign of the v12 build that preserves the existing battle engine while transforming the world, presentation, roster, AI behaviour, language, art direction and emotional tone.

CORE PROMISE

You are not a hero rising through a tournament. You are a captive vessel being forged by an ancient, failing god. Every duel is a rite. Every victory binds a consciousness. Every card is a prison that remembers.

1. Purpose and non-negotiable principles

This revision updates the existing redesign plan using the latest direction: the roster must not be presented as heroes, villains, or antiheroes; all combatants are mystical beings; the atmosphere must feel like horror-leaning grim dark fantasy; and AI opponents must behave like old, uncanny entities rather than expressive anime characters.

• **Gameplay remains frozen.** Preserve HP, POWER/RANK calls, tiers, boosts, cooldowns, Last Stand, placement tables, Arena Pressure, Monarque interventions, wild-card timing and the shared Battle/Story engine unless a separately approved balance change is required.

• **Identity before cosmetic reskin.** Change narrative framing, visual language, names, dialogue, animation and audio together. Do not simply darken colourful anime assets.

• **Every opponent is a being, not a moral alignment.** Gods, demons, spirits, yokai, primordial forces and legendary monsters are captive candidates. Their motives and temperaments differ; none is labelled good or evil by the UI.

• **Ancient intelligence, not anime performance.** Opponents speak rarely, act with intent, and communicate through restraint, ritual, stillness and unsettling behaviour.

• **Implied horror, not graphic gore.** Souls are compressed into card stock, seals, silhouettes and fractured voices. Keep it disturbing without explicit gore.

• **Original IP presentation.** Use public-domain mythology as source material, not franchise-specific designs, powers, costumes, catchphrases or signature poses.

2. Tone direction: occult dread

The player should feel watched, contained and tested inside a place that existed before human ideas of good and evil. Horror comes from the implication that the beings understand the stakes better than the player does.

Pillar	Direction	Avoid
Dread	Slow anticipation, silence, distant movement, a sense of being observed	Constant jump scares or loud stingers
Grime	Ash, soot, cracked stone, old wax, tarnished metal, bone, old blood as a restrained accent	Clean sci-fi panels, glossy gradients, candy colours
Mysticism	Seals, sigils, ritual geometry, relics, forbidden names, impossible architecture	Generic magic sparkles or superhero energy blasts
Body/soul horror	Silhouette drawn into a card; shadow struggling under a seal; breath trapped behind paper	Graphic dismemberment or explicit gore
Age	Weathered surfaces, eroded inscriptions, voices that sound patient and inhuman	Modern slang, meme humour, catchphrases
Restraint	Rare dialogue; animation and sound carry meaning	Constant quips, exaggerated facial reactions, shouty victory poses

3. World premise and emotional spine

Monarque is a powerful celestial sovereign whose existence has stretched across eons. Nothing beneath him has been strong enough to truly engage him. He creates a tournament as an experiment: the beings taken from their realms are forced to fight, adapt and consume the power of the defeated until one vessel can endure a fragment of his Essence.

Monarque is not a smug showman. He is a dying, terrified god trying to manufacture something capable of surviving him—or giving his final existence meaning. His authority remains frightening, but the Unraveling gradually reveals panic, memory failure and loss of control.

The contestants are not willing champions. They are abducted, bound and compelled to compete. They may be proud, predatory, calculating, ancient, resentful or resigned, but their behaviour should never imply a simple hero-versus-villain morality.

The central emotional progression is: **captivity → adaptation → dread of binding → impossible transfer of Essence → Monarque's collapse → release.**

4. Core vocabulary and UI language

Keep engine identifiers and effect IDs unchanged wherever possible. Use a display-name mapping so the presentation can change without breaking tests or AI logic.

Current term	Display term	Meaning
Game Master / GM	Monarque	The failing celestial who conducts the rite; internal gm IDs remain unchanged
Ki	Soul	Existing reserve; same values and caps
Charge Ki	Gather Soul	Existing action and costs remain unchanged
Character cards	Bound-being cards	Imprisoned mystical consciousnesses
Fighter power / claimed power	Signature / Soulbound power	A defeated being's power becomes bound to the victor
Wild Card	Edict (Monarque) / Power (player)	Existing slot and one-per-round rule
APEX card	Soulbound card	A high-tier being/power under the new fiction
Step I / II / III	Resistance / Adaptation / Stability	Existing progression tiers
Entertainment meter	Monarque's Interest	Existing meter, now framed as the god measuring the vessel
Decrees	Monarque's Whims	Existing events and effects, renamed in the UI
Keepsake	Echo	Existing carry-forward reward, if retained
The Curse	The Unraveling	An escalating drain and a sign of failing containment

4.1 Wild-card display names

Effect ID (unchanged)	Display name	Function
SENZU	Last Draught	Recovery
FINAL_ATONEMENT	The Reckoning	Burst; both lose HP and round ends
OTHER_WORLD	The Inverted Realm	Lower stat wins
SOLAR_FLARE	Blinding Eclipse	Blind play
SCOUTER	Oracle's Gaze	Insight report
SHENRON_WISH	Monarque's Boon	Existing boon choices
MAFUBA	The Binding Seal	Seals a played card
CURSE	The Unraveling	Escalating drain

Keep the mechanics of existing crazy rounds. Rename only the presentation: Wish Round → The Boon Round; Zenkai Rush → Desperate Surge. Dragon Ball Draft → The Culling Draft. Other decree names should use ritual, relic, trial and

omen vocabulary, not anime terminology.

5. AI opponents: ancient temperaments

Remove the Heroes, Villains, Antiheroes and Monsters groups from all player-facing language and all dialogue logic that depends on moral alignment. The AI needs temperament profiles instead. If the existing code relies on group fields, keep those fields as compatibility keys internally and map them to new temperament IDs/display labels; do not let the old labels leak into UI or dialogue.

Temperament	Core presence	Behavioural expression	Dialogue style
Sovereigns	Proud, contemptuous, used to being obeyed	Prefer strong, controlled plays; avoid desperate-looking boosts when the existing AI weights allow; do not yield easily	Imperatives, dismissive certainty, the assumption that lesser things will kneel
Deceivers	Patient, unreadable, predatory through uncertainty	Bluff and bait; vary calls to make patterns hard to read; exploit the player's habits	Half-truths, questions that are not really questions, warnings that may be lies
Devourers	Hungry, reactive, drawn to weakness	Become more aggressive when the opponent is low; commit to pressure rather than retreat	Sensory language: hunger, warmth, pulse, scent, the taste of fear
The Ancient and Patient	Indifferent, inexhaustibly old, almost geological	Conserve resources; wait for high-value opportunities; avoid needless display	Sparse observations, long pauses, statements that make the current duel seem trivial

These are not four alignments or classes of good and evil. They are behavioural lenses. A single kind of mystical being could be written as a Sovereign in one interpretation and a Deceiver in another. Keep the existing AI architecture where practical; tune weights and selection rules rather than introducing a new combat system.

6. AI emotional model and voice rules

Replace cheerful victory, frustration and anime-style hype with an emotional vocabulary rooted in dread and predatory intent. The emotions should be conveyed through sparse text, pauses, posture, sound and changes in the environment.

• **Dread:** the being realises the seal is near. It speaks about the card, the silence inside it, or the loss of its name.

• **Contempt:** a Sovereign treats the duel as an inconvenience or the player as a temporary vessel.

• **Hunger:** a Devourer notices injury, dwindling Soul or a vulnerable play as something to consume.

• **Resignation:** an old being accepts a likely defeat without begging or theatrical despair.

• **Fury:** controlled and frightening, expressed through stillness, clipped words and harsher animation rather than shouting.

• **Cold calm:** an ancient being responds to a decisive event as if it has watched the same outcome happen across centuries.

• **Fracture:** reserved for the Corrupted warrior and Monarque as the Unraveling destroys coherence; phrases shorten, repeat and lose nouns.

6.1 Dialogue rules

• Speak rarely. Use one short line at a meaningful breakpoint rather than chatter after every action.

• No exclamation marks, meme language, modern slang, catchphrases, celebratory banter or phrases such as “lucky hit.”

• Do not narrate obvious gameplay. Lines should reveal the being's worldview or the cost of losing.

• Use archaic but readable language. Avoid making every line pseudo-Shakespearean; each temperament needs a distinct cadence.

• Silence is a valid response. Some events should trigger only a breath, a chain sound, a dimming candle or a card's faint movement.

• Winning is not joyful. It may produce relief, appetite, contempt, or no visible reaction.

• Losing is not a normal defeat. It is the terror of being flattened into a card and losing name, body, voice and freedom.

6.2 Tone Bible: sample lines

Temperament	Sample lines
Sovereign	“Kneel. I will not repeat the shape of the command.” “You mistake endurance for permission.” “I was old when your heavens were young.”
Deceiver	“You have seen this move before. Or believe you have.” “Choose carefully. I have chosen for you already.” “There is a door behind the seal. It opens inward.”
Devourer	“Your wound has a voice.” “I can smell the moment your resolve thins.” “Do not die yet. I have not finished feeding.”
The Ancient and Patient	“Again, the little wheel turns.” “I have waited through brighter endings.” “This struggle will become dust. You may remain.”
Dread / binding	“Not the card. Not the silence inside it.” “Keep my name outside the seal.” “I can feel the edges closing.”
Monarque, early	“The vessel has endured.” “Continue. I require a stronger answer.” “Let the next rite begin.”
Monarque, fraying	“The seal… no. The seal was…” “I made you. I made—” “No more. No more. No—”

These lines are examples of tone, not a requirement to reuse them everywhere. Write a ban-list check for anime/franchise phrases, jokes, exclamation-heavy lines, modern slang and generic “hero/villain” labels. Keep a shared glossary of preferred words: rite, vessel, seal, binding, ash, marrow, hush, echo, threshold, hunger, witness, debt, name, relic, fracture, unmaking, and release.

7. Monarque: a frightened god, not a showman

Monarque's menace should come from power and scale, not smugness. He created the tournament because nothing could challenge him; now the experiment is producing a vessel whose Essence may exceed its capacity. He needs the experiment to succeed, yet fears what success will unleash.

• **Early rounds:** composed, measured, clinical. He speaks as a being accustomed to having reality obey.

• **Middle rounds:** brief hints of attachment to the experiment. He watches the vessel with something close to need, then disguises it as command.

• **Round 6 / Corrupted warrior:** his control is exposed as imperfect. The transfer of Essence is unintended, not a triumphant gift.

• **Final bouts:** the Unraveling erodes his syntax, memory and timing. He repeats fragments, contradicts earlier statements and occasionally forgets what he was about to command.

• **Ending:** the collapse is not a villain's defeat speech. His authority fails; the seals fracture; the beings are released. The last sound may be his breath disappearing into the silence.

Retain Monarque's Interest as the existing entertainment meter under a new name. It is not a literal amusement gauge; it measures his increasingly desperate assessment of the vessel. Keep intervention logic unchanged unless later balancing is separately approved.

8. Essence, containment and the Corrupted

Keep three concepts distinct in story and UI: **Total Essence** is the quantity of power a being possesses; **Essence concentration** is how much power is packed into a given portion; **containment capacity** is what a vessel can safely hold. These are not interchangeable measurements.

• Monarque's Essence concentration is nearly four times that of the strongest being beneath him. This establishes a qualitative gulf; it does not mean his total Essence is exactly four times greater.

• After Round 6, the champion receives one-third of Monarque's Essence through an unintended transfer. This is a fraction of his total Essence, not a claim that the transfer has the same concentration or is automatically safe.

• The champion's Resistance, Adaptation and Stability are narrative readings of existing progression, not new currencies. A Strain indicator may be derived from existing Soul and Step values, but it must not secretly change combat outcomes.

• The Corrupted warrior represents concentration exceeding containment capacity. Use the existing Unraveling effect and a power rider as already proposed; their dialogue should fracture as their body and identity fail.

• Monarque's late Unraveling communicates that even an entity with immense Essence can lose control when its coherence fails.

Avoid implying that a third of Monarque's Essence makes the champion instantly equal to Monarque. The transfer is dangerous, incomplete in control, and filtered through a vessel that is still adapting. That tension is the reason the final battle matters.

9. Roster: 32 mystical beings, no moral categories

The roster should be curated around mythic dread and unsettling interpretations. Use the mythology itself; do not copy modern franchise versions. Each entry keeps its current grade, signature mechanic and simulation role, but receives a temperament, type line, short description and original signature name. These are candidate identities to review against the actual existing mechanic mapping before implementation.

Candidate being	Mythic framing	Existing mechanic to preserve	Temperament
Loki	Norse shapeshifter / deceiver	Rule inversion	Deceiver
Tamamo-no-Mae	Japanese fox spirit	Clone and cooldown reset	Deceiver
Achilles	Greek death-haunted warrior	Refuses to fall, then hits harder	Sovereign
Heracles	Greek demigod in the shadow of madness	Pay HP for double power	Devourer
Ibaraki-d■ji	Japanese oni	Overdrive with a self-cost	Devourer
Hel	Norse ruler of the dead	Self-sacrificing burst	Ancient and Patient
Benkei	Japanese revenant-like warrior	Takes no loss on defeat	Sovereign
Odin	Norse god of sacrifice and knowledge	Records and copies cards	Ancient and Patient
Hades	Greek underworld ruler	Reverse a lost round	Sovereign

Candidate being	Mythic framing	Existing mechanic to preserve	Temperament
Susanoo	Japanese storm deity	Damage cap, stops boosts	Devourer
Set	Egyptian god of disorder and desert	Forces opponent's tier	Deceiver
Hermes	Greek psychopomp and boundary-crosser	Steals the played card	Deceiver
Cronus	Greek primordial ruler	Steals a power	Sovereign
Abe no Seimei	Japanese onmy■ji tradition	Spirits spent for power	Deceiver
Agamemnon	Greek king stained by sacrifice	Sacrifices cards for power	Sovereign
Apep	Egyptian chaos serpent	Negates a power	Devourer
Orestes	Greek figure pursued by the Furies	Undo a lost round	Dread / hunted
Jor■gumo	Japanese spider y■kai	Extends cooldowns	Deceiver
Starkaðr	Norse legendary figure	Rage builds with losses	Devourer
Baal	Ancient Near Eastern deity / later demonological figure	Brutal bonus at higher cost	Sovereign
Thoth	Egyptian god of writing and reckoning	Prepared trap on a tier	Ancient and Patient
Skuld	Norse fate-associated figure	Dice of fate	Ancient and Patient
Horus	Egyptian sky deity	Sees opponent's state	Sovereign
Sigurd	Norse legendary dragon-slayer	Immune to targeting	Sovereign
Khepri	Egyptian scarab-associated deity	Adapts after each loss	Ancient and Patient
Yamata no Orochi	Japanese eight-headed serpent	Doubles stakes	Devourer
Abaddon	Apocalyptic destroyer / demonological name	Erases healing and prevention	Devourer
Shuten-d■ji	Japanese oni	Domain that drains each round	Devourer
Sekhmet	Egyptian lioness deity of plague and violence	Heals, then punishes	Devourer
Fenrir	Norse monstrous wolf	Bonus against higher tiers	Devourer
Lilith	Mesopotamian/Jewish demonological traditions; interpret carefully	Permanently deforms a card	Deceiver
Ammit	Egyptian devourer of the unworthy	Pays HP instead of Soul	Devourer

Roster caveat: mythology is diverse and sometimes contested. Treat these as creative candidates, not claims that every tradition defines a being identically. Validate names, cultural framing and the current v12 mechanic mapping before locking the final roster. If a name reads as too heroic or familiar, choose a darker mythic figure with the same mechanic rather than forcing the tone.

10. The 80 bound-being cards

• Preserve the current 80-card count and all Power, Rank and tier values: 5 OP, 23 Powerful, 42 Normal and 10 Weak, unless balancing is separately approved.

• OP cards should evoke primordial or world-ending presences; Powerful cards major gods, great demons and ancient monsters; Normal cards lesser gods, spirits and uncanny entities; Weak / Last Stand cards minor spirits, fragments and lesser demons.

• Every card receives an invocation line and a freedom line. The first makes the entity feel present inside the card; the second releases it without turning the ending into a victory parade.

• Replace the existing character images. Until commissioned art is ready, use original sigils, restrained silhouettes and a chain-and-wax-seal frame, not generated anime emblems.

• Show the being's silhouette compressed beneath the card surface. Binding should look like a ritual closing, not a collectible-card sparkle.

• Visual cracks may accumulate as a purely cosmetic consequence of repeated invocation. Do not make them affect gameplay.

10.1 Example card voice

Moment	Example
Invocation	“Open the seal. I will lend you the shape of my hunger.”
Resistance / strain	“Careful. The vessel is thinner than it appears.”
Defeat / binding	“No. Not the small dark. Anything but the small dark.”
Freedom	“The edge has broken. I remember the sky.”

11. Visual art direction and UI

The interface should feel like an instrument of confinement: legible, severe and tactile. The game remains usable first; ornament must never hide stats, calls or available actions.

Element	Art direction
Palette	Ash black, soot, bone, iron grey, tarnished gold; old blood used sparingly as an alert accent
Materials	Engraved iron, cracked stone, wax, vellum, corroded bronze, bone inlay, smoke-dark glass
Typography	A restrained, readable serif for titles and ritual labels; a clear high-legibility face for stats and controls
Cards	Worn edges, chain details, seal stamps, restrained sigils, trapped silhouettes; tier distinction through material and engraving, not neon rarity colours
Arena	Sealed ossuary, black cathedral or impossible subterranean sanctum; distant pillars, hanging chains, candle smoke and negative space
Motion	Slow reveal, slight parallax, dust, smoke, seal tightening, a shadow resisting from inside the card; no bouncy or celebratory motion
HUD	Soul as reserve; derived Strain indicator only if it does not add a new resource; Monarque's Interest as a thin, uneasy flame
Victory	Quiet, ritualistic, almost administrative; a seal is stamped and the defeated presence is contained
Defeat	The arena darkens, sound narrows, and the player sees the vessel's failure rather than a comic/game-over flourish
Accessibility	Maintain strong contrast, readable text, reduced-motion option and clear status cues; horror should not impair core play

11.1 Sound and music

• Keep the existing dark synthesized music as a base, but audition and mix it with the actual game; the current plan notes that the audio has not yet been heard by a person.

• Layer low, restrained textures: distant whispers, slow breathing, chain drag, wax cracking, paper under tension, stone settling and sub-bass pressure.

• Reserve sharp transient sounds for rare moments: a binding seal closing, an edict misfiring, the first crack in Monarque's authority.

• Use silence and reduced ambience as a deliberate event. Do not place a voice line over every action.

• Voices should feel close, dry and controlled; avoid exaggerated anime delivery, shouting and comic timing.

12. Story beats and existing mechanics

Story beat	Existing mechanic / presentation
Defeated soul is bound	Claim choice becomes a short sealing ritual
Soul Consumption	Ki is renamed Soul; costs remain tier-based: OP 5, Powerful 3, Normal 1, Last Stand 0
Containment improves	Steps I / II / III become Resistance / Adaptation / Stability
Early invocations strain the vessel	A text warning at Resistance when Soul is low; no new combat penalty
Monarque studies the vessel	Existing entertainment meter becomes Monarque's Interest
Corrupted warrior deteriorates	Existing Unraveling plus the established power rider; dialogue fragments with falling HP
Unintended Essence transfer	After Round 6, one-time Monarque's Boon / Essence Fragment, using an existing wild-card family
Monarque loses coherence	Late Unraveling and unreliable edict telegraphing as already proposed
Seals fail	Ending shatters bound cards and frees the beings

Keep Soul as a rename of the existing resource in the first pass. Do not introduce per-card costs or a second currency until the game is tested and that change is explicitly approved. Shop, coins and Draw must be checked against the current build before removal: changing them is a gameplay decision, not just a tone change.

13. Round 6, final bouts and ending

Retain the three-bout finale in the current redesign unless a deliberate story decision changes it. Frame the bouts as Monarque's attempts to overwrite the vessel rather than a conventional boss gauntlet.

• **Bout I — Contact:** Monarque probes the vessel. His edicts are controlled and deliberate.

• **Bout II — Pressure:** his command grows more forceful; his coherence begins to slip.

• **Bout III — Fading:** the Unraveling is visible in his timing, language and telegraphs. He remains dangerous but is no longer fully in control.

• The Second Chance is a return from Monarque's grip, not a cheerful retry screen.

• On the final blow, Monarque's seal-authority collapses. Bound cards crack and open; silhouettes emerge; each released being gets a concise freedom line.

• Keep the Echo/Keepsake decision separate from the tone update. If retained, the Echo is a being that chooses to remain—not a reward trophy.

14. Additional features that support the tone

• **Binding ritual:** a brief animation and sound on the claim screen, with the defeated silhouette drawn into a card and sealed.

• **Grudge:** if the existing profile system can support it cleanly, remember a narrow defeat and let it inform the Corrupted warrior selection; keep optional.

• **Chorus of the Freed:** beings most often invoked may withhold one cosmetic/fictional edict during the ending sequence, only if this maps cleanly to existing burned-edict logic.

• **Run recap:** list beings bound, the strongest grudge, and Monarque's final coherent—or fractured—line.

• **Another Cycle:** frame the daily seed as another repetition of the experiment, without undermining the true ending.

15. Work plan

Phase	Work	Acceptance check
0 — Freeze	Tag v12; record current tests; create display-name map; preserve effect IDs, schema keys and compatibility fields; remove old franchise documentation and stray notes before release	Baseline build and tests recorded; no identifiers changed accidentally
1 — Narrative data	Replace hero/villain labels with temperament mapping; rewrite 32 roster entries, signature names, 80 card names/flavor lines, wild cards, whims and round names	No moral-alignment labels leak into UI; every entity has temperament and original copy
2 — AI voice	Implement rare reaction timing, emotion vocabulary, four temperament styles and the Monarque fracture progression	No slang, jokes, exclamation-heavy taunts or anime catchphrases; behavioural profiles remain distinct
3 — Art/UI	Replace portraits, arenas, GM scenes, card frames, menu, HUD and wild-card art; add seal, silhouette and cosmetic crack states	No glossy anime look; all core controls and stats remain legible
4 — Sound/story	Mix whispers, chains, breath and seal sounds; implement opening, binding ritual, Corrupted dialogue, finale and recap	Audio auditioned by a person; dialogue cadence matches Tone Bible
5 — Essence presentation	Clarify total Essence vs concentration vs containment; implement only derived Strain and existing Unraveling beats	No new currency or hidden combat rules; transfer reads as dangerous and unintended
6 — QA/balance	Fix round-50 stalemate; verify Vite build; rerun simulations and regression tests; tune finale separately if needed	Battle Mode unchanged; Story Mode passes tests; final difficulty measured rather than guessed

16. Quality gates and risks

Risk	Mitigation / test
Old franchise IP leaks	Search all source strings, assets, filenames, docs and audio metadata; automated banned-term check
Anime tone survives in AI	Review sample play sessions; measure line frequency; ban modern slang, catchphrases and theatrical shouting
Roster still feels like heroes and villains	Remove alignment language from UI, prompts, dialogue selection and documentation; assign temperaments instead
Grim palette hurts usability	Test contrast, card readability, status clarity, reduced motion and colour-independent cues
Tone becomes generic gothic fantasy	Use specific ritual details, distinct temperament voices, cultural research and the Essence/containment premise
Gameplay regression	Keep effect IDs and rule code unchanged; run existing tests and Battle Mode regression
Essence lore contradiction	Maintain a glossary separating total Essence, concentration and containment capacity

Risk	Mitigation / test
Final boss too easy or unfair	Test each bout separately; tune edict count and Unraveling presentation without changing general match rules

17. Decisions and implementation defaults

The following defaults are recommended so the redesign can proceed without reopening every earlier choice:

• **Roster framing:** approve mystical beings only; remove Heroes, Villains, Antiheroes and Monsters from player-facing design.

• **AI:** use Sovereigns, Deceivers, Devourers and The Ancient and Patient as temperament profiles, mapped onto existing AI hooks where possible.

• **Tone:** grim dark fantasy with implied soul/body horror, restrained dialogue, no jokes and no anime-style reactions.

• **Gameplay:** freeze core combat rules and preserve IDs. Soul remains a rename of Ki in the first pass.

• **Essence:** explicitly distinguish total quantity, concentration and vessel capacity; the one-third transfer is unintended and does not instantly make the champion Monarque's equal.

• **Art and audio:** replace glossy/bright assets; use ash, bone, iron, tarnished gold, wax seals, chains, silhouettes, whispers and slow breathing.

• **Final:** retain the three-bout finale for now, with Monarque's fading coherence and the release of all bound beings.

• **Optional features:** keep Grudge, Chorus of the Freed and Echo behind scope review; none should delay the tone, roster and AI overhaul.

> The success criterion is not simply that the game looks darker. The player should feel that every opponent has a private, inhuman history; that the AI is choosing with intent rather than performing for an audience; and that victory is an act of binding which leaves a moral and emotional stain.